

Rules of Design<=>Wording engagement

Abstract

This paper explains the rules of engagement that have been in use between Evolution and Core, amends the rules with regards to Evolutionary wording review, and proposes adopting the same rules between Library Evolution and Library.

The amendment to the rules should change nothing for Core and Library (well, not for worse, at least), it's merely a wording-runthrough in EWG and LEWG before the material proceeds for technical/wording review.

The <=> in the title is not a spaceship, it's two overlapping arrows going into opposite directions.

Revision history

Highlight the most recent changes: ☐

- R1: This version, added clarifications for
 1. what the qualifications of a wordsmith are,
 2. how to find wordsmiths, and
 3. how a WG can choose to do a small-group wording pre-review instead of relying on a single individual wordsmith to do it
- R0: Initial version

Some historical background

The original problem

Way back when, not really important when, but a couple of years ago, we had three problematic issues with material that flowed from Evolution to Core:

- some material didn't have wording when it arrived on Core's plate.
- some material had wording that hadn't been pre-reviewed by a Core expert.
- some material needed to be sent back to Evolution, and Evolution wasn't always prepared nor welcoming of such an event of material being sent back.

The solution

To alleviate these problems, the Chair of Evolution specified the following rules, although they weren't written down (a snag that this document aims to rectify):

- a proposal forwarded to Core must have wording; this is not negotiable, and Core shouldn't and doesn't entertain suggestions for fishing expeditions, they are busy.

- such wording must be either written by a recognized wordsmith or reviewed by one.
- if, for any reason, Core thinks they need a design clarification or have any other question or a challenge about the design, the rule is to send the material back to Evolution accompanied by a member of Core that can explain the problem.

Notably, regardless of whether it's

- a "please clarify", or
- a "please reconsider", or
- a "we think this stinks",

the rule is the same - send it back and worry about possible hurt egos later. Core is not a design group, but they have enough experience that they are allowed and invited to challenge designs that make no sense to them. And in any case, Core shouldn't try to resolve design issues in Core, that's Evolution's job and Evolutions responsibility, and at the very least Evolution should understand the Core-technical consequences of their decisions.

The rationale for these points shouldn't be hard to understand:

- Core is supposed to review a technical specification and make sure it's worded suitably, accurately, and consistently, and wording-wise and otherwise fits into the language. Doing so requires having the actual wording that is proposed to be incorporated into the Working Draft.
 - Core doesn't write wording.
 - Some members of Core might be so kind to help write wording.
- Core's workload is hefty, and the time of the experts in that room is not used well if they are looking at a specification that is nowhere near ready to have a chance to survive the first 5 minutes of review before there is a request to go away and come back with proper wording. This is both about consistency and completeness - the wording should be roughly similar to the wording we already have terminology-wise, style-wise and otherwise, and it must have all the things that are part of the design.
 - Core doesn't write wording.
 - Some members of Core might be so kind to help write wording.

The process

Once these issues were recognized and the alleviation for them agreed on, we established the following process for Design->Wording:

- Evolution reviews a proposal, and decides they are happy with it and want to forward it to Core.
- The EWGChair queries/verifies the existence of the wording.
 - In case it doesn't exist, the instructions for the paper author are "find a wordsmith, produce wording, and report back to me".
 - In case it exists, the question is "has it been reviewed by a reputable wordsmith? If not, have it so reviewed and report back to me."
- Once EWGChair is satisfied with the reputable wordsmith's report that the wording is ready for Core consumption, Core is made aware of incoming material and the proposal author is greenlighted to proceed to Core review at Core's scheduling pleasure.

And, as mentioned earlier, the following process for Design<-Wording:

- Core reviews a proposal, and discovers a design issue.
- The CWGChair notifies EWGChair that something needs to come back, and designates a Core champion to explain the issue in Evolution.
- EWGChair schedules such a discussion with elevated priority, and we iterate again, with the Design<->Wording rules as before.

The New Rules

Rather than the chair of a design group making sure that wording exists and is ready for the technical/wording review group's consumption, that responsibility now lies with the whole design group. That is, once the proposal author has made sure their wording is either written by a wordsmith or reviewed by one, they approach the design group (with the wordsmith) and give a presentation about the wording, illustrating how it implements the design, and report whether any oddities or questions surfaced. If such oddities or questions did surface, the design group needs to discuss them and possibly clarify their design.

This rule change is made for a couple of reasons:

- the design groups must understand the technical consequences of their designs
- the design groups must double-check that the design is accurately implemented by the wording, instead of saying very late in the process that "that's not what we meant" or "that's against the design intent".

"What's a 'wordsmith'? Who qualifies?"

A wordsmith is, by the definition for the purposes of this process, "a person who can write or help write CWG/LWG-consumable wording". It's ultimately the decision of the chairs of EWG/LEWG to decide what sort of wording they're willing to accept as wording incoming into their wording review (which might be less strict than the wording-group review), and those groups should have confidence that what they forward is written and championed by a person that won't be wasting Core's or Library's time.

CWG and LWG can also, if they so choose, arrange for a small group of their members to do this wording-work. Note, however, that such arranging must not consume group time, and is not the responsibility of the chair of the wording review group. Ask the members of EWG/LEWG to help you when the initial design review is done, ask a wordsmith that you know, ask on the reflector, but do not spend CWG's or LWG's time in the quest for a wordsmith.

Further explanation of the new process

So, to sum it up, let's bulletize the Design->Wording process:

1. the design group, be it LEWG or EWG, decides after reviewing a proposal that it should go forward to LWG or CWG.
2. if the proposal has wording, the design group must run through it and verify that the design is wholly and accurately implemented by the wording, and that there are neither omissions nor additions that the design doesn't cover.
3. if the proposal does not have wording, the design group must not greenlight the proposal to go forward; they must instead instruct the proposal to come back with the wording.
4. when the proposal has new wording not yet reviewed in the second bullet, go back to the second bullet. Repeat as many times as necessary.
5. once the run-through is complete, and the design group is confident that the wording implements the design wholly and accurately, the design group sends the material onwards, forwards.

Let's also bulletize the Design<-Wording process:

1. the wording/technical review group reviews a proposal and discovers a design-level addition/omission/bug/issue/snag, or a technical problem (an implementability problem, a consistency problem, or some other problem).
2. the chair of the wording/technical review group makes sure the problem is minuted, sends a heads-up to the chair of the design group, and designates a champion that can explain the problem to the design group.
3. the design group reviews the matter, and resolves it according to the Design->Wording process.
4. the wording/technical review group continues progress on the proposal.

Or in a diagram:

